

St. Cyril of Alexandria: The Seal of the Fathers

By Dn Yonnas · Christology · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

The life and teaching of St. Cyril (Abba Kirillos), 24th Pope of Alexandria, and his defense of the unity of Christ against Nestorius. The lesson explains the error of dividing Christ into two persons, the meaning of Theotokos, the iron-and-fire analogy of the Tewahedo union, the Council of Ephesus (431 AD), and why our Church bears the name Tewahedo.

Lesson Objectives

- Tell who St. Cyril was and why he is called the Seal of the Fathers
- Explain the Nestorian error and why the Church rejected it
- Confess the Tewahedo union: one incarnate nature of God the Word, without mixture, confusion, change, or division

Key Bible Verses

John 1:14 — "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us"

Luke 1:43 — "the mother of my Lord"

John 10:30 — "I and My Father are one."

Main Teaching Points

- The Word did not merely dwell in a man — the Word became man
- Nestorius divided Christ into two persons and rejected the title Theotokos
- If Mary is not the Mother of God, then the One born of her is not truly God — and we are not truly saved
- Iron in fire: united and acting as one, without confusion and without separation
- At the Council of Ephesus (431 AD) the Church affirmed Theotokos and the one Christ
- Our Church is called Tewahedo ('made one') because of this very faith, confessed in every Kidassie

Key Terms

- **Tewahedo** — Ge'ez for 'made one' — the perfect union of divinity and humanity in the one Christ.
- **Theotokos** — Greek for 'God-bearer' / Mother of God — the title of St. Mary defended at Ephesus.
- **Nestorianism** — The condemned teaching that Christ is two separate persons, one divine and one human.
- **Mia Physis** — St. Cyril's formula: 'one incarnate nature of God the Word' — unity without confusion or division.

Discussion & Reflection

- How does knowing Christ is both fully God and fully man change your faith?
- Why does honoring St. Mary as Theotokos protect the truth about Christ?
- How can you defend the unity of Christ when others say He was only a teacher or prophet?